Scare Factor

A Horror Film Fear Website

Website Link

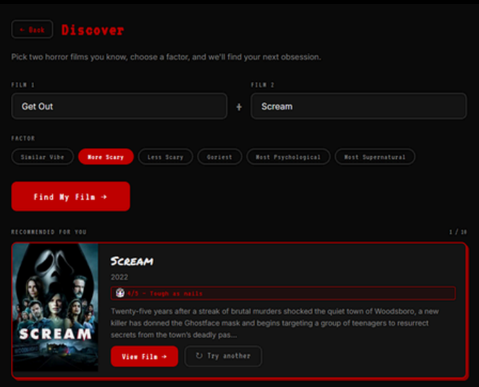
Github Repository Link

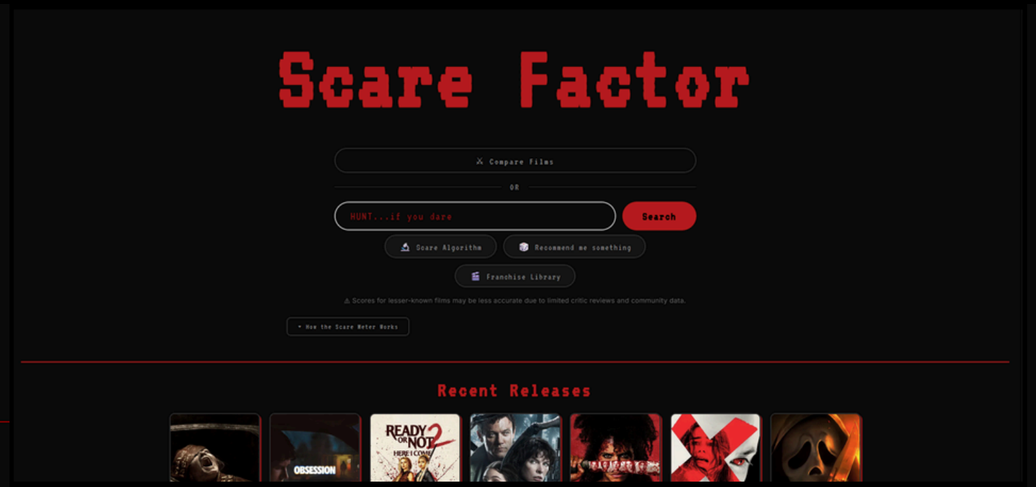
Campbell Smith

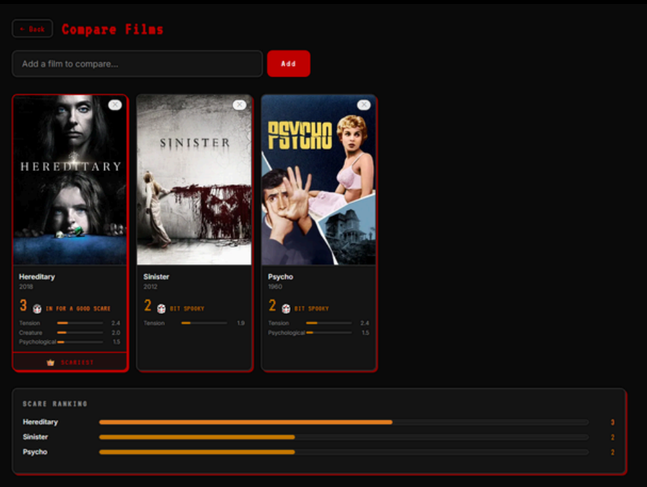
Introduction

Scare Factor is a website that looks at horror film reviews for keywords and predicts how scary a film is, giving it a rating between one and five based on common horror film traits, such as Gore, Psychological, Slasher, Paranormal, Occult, and demonic, weighted to the most common fears of consumers.

Scare Factor changes the way horror movie fans interact with the discovery of horror films, it creates a way for them to engage with new films, and relate it to ones they have already seen.



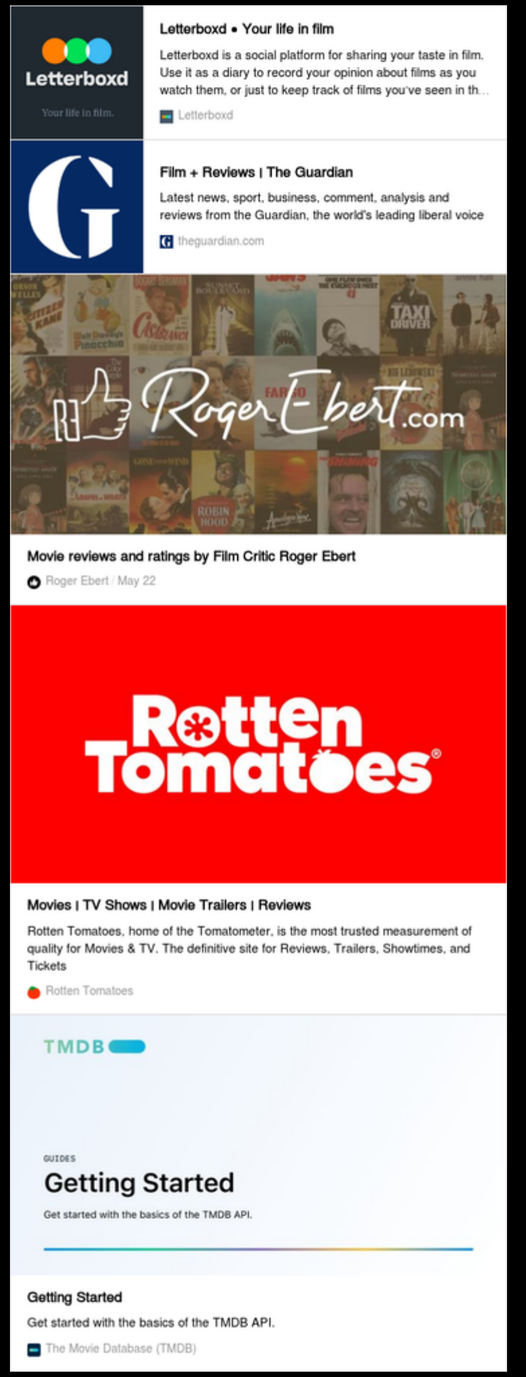




APIs

Scare Factor runs primarily on TMDB's api, looking at reviews for key words to understand the scare factor of each film. Once the film's profile is opened Claude looks at a few other sources in the background to ensure the rating's accuracy, theses are The Guardian, Rotten Tomatoes, Letterboxd, and Roger Ebert.

The algorithm for determining the scare factor of each film is searching for keywords in reviews that correlate with common horror troupes and factors, these are Gore, Supernatural, Psychological, Slasher, Demonic, Creature, Tension and Occult.

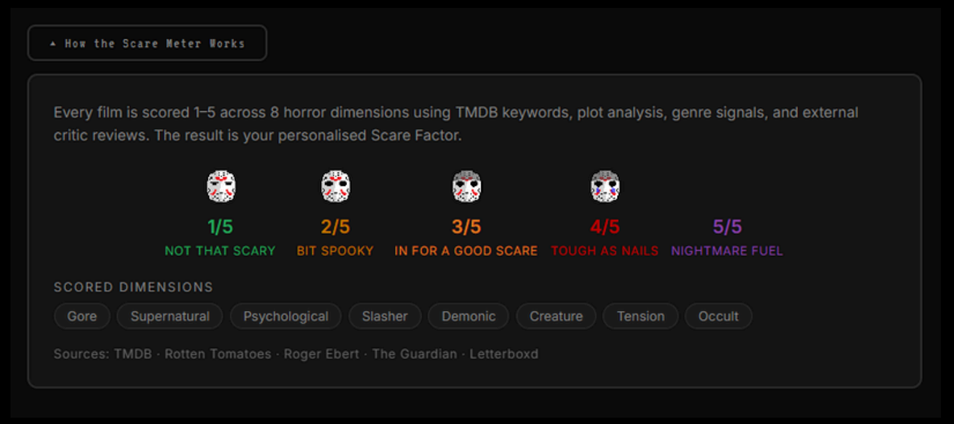


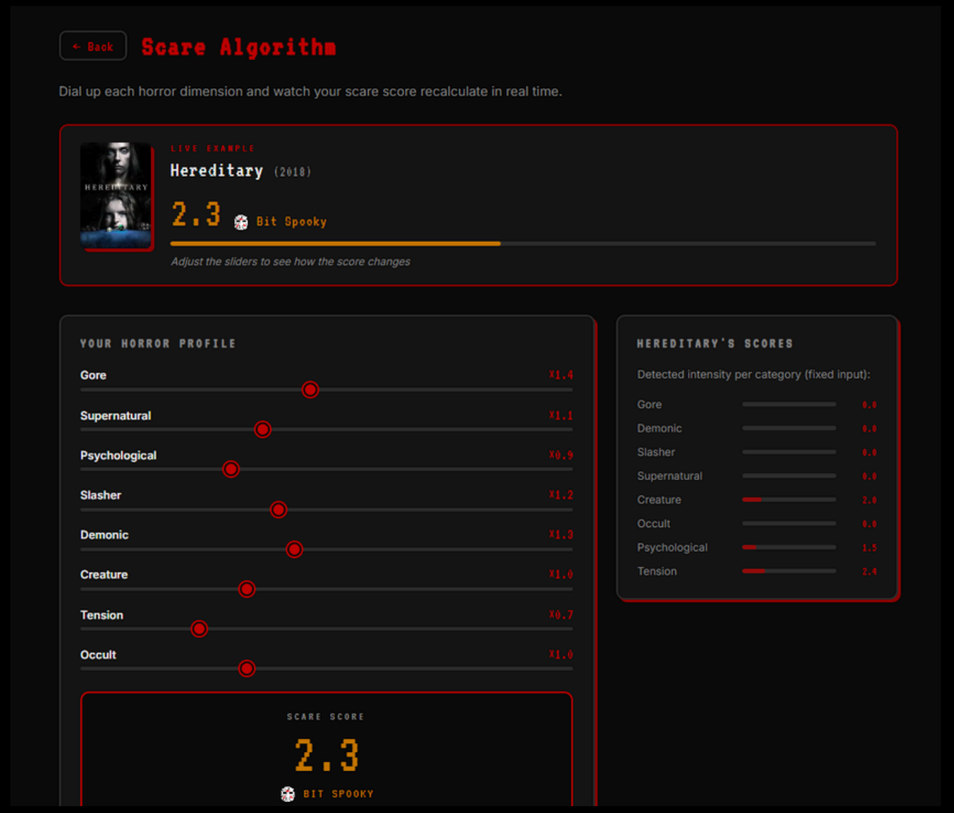
How it Works

As discussed in the introduction, scare factor scores horror films from one to five, based on keywords in reviews. Claude is actively linked to TMDB's API to pull quickfire scores, and when a user opens a specific film page it pulls further data from other review wesites to balance the films score.

Users also have a customise algorithm option on the homepage, where they can change the factor sliders to more acurately represent their personal fears when it comes to horror films.

This creates a direct type of ranking system of horror films, entirely based on how scary each one is, but hopefully users understand this doesn't represent quality, or take it as a challenge.

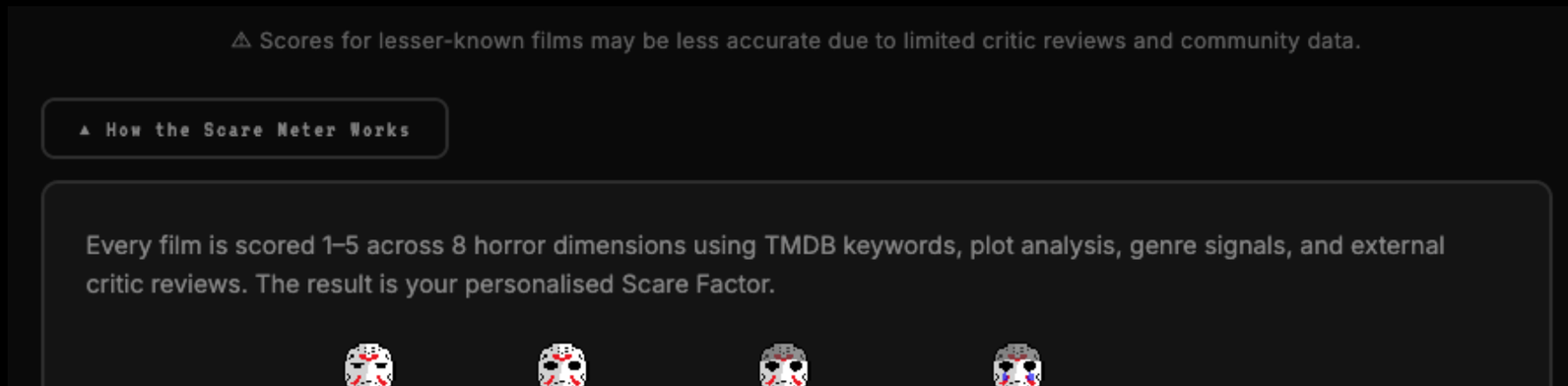




Weight and Collaboration

Intial Scores are weighed by Claude’s alorithm, and then can be changed by users. This choice was made to allow users to get a sense of how scary a film is to a general audience, and then adapt the algorithm through the users choice for those particularly sensitive to certian factors, or can stomach more intense factors to create a more personalised output.

Claude was used to develop the main framework of the site, and then prompted through the different webpages. The fators within the algorithm were determined by Claude, with my input to add gore and psychological. The default algorithm pushed and created ratings I didn’t personally agree with, and then my testing users didn’t agree with, in quote “That film kept me up at night how is it only a one”, which led me to add a warning on the home screen that films with less reviews would be less acurate.



Reflection

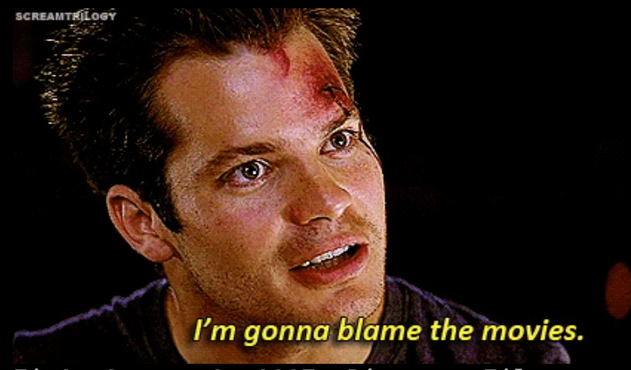


Fig1, Scream 2, 1997. Dimenson Films

The reading that most resonated with me was Our Phony Economy, looking at the scare factor site if it were to replace how people look at films, or the film rating system I think it would create an overall negative impact on horror film viewing, pushing people to seek out more intense material. Theres a lot of research and discussion into the psychological effects witnessing extreme violence causing apathy which I won't dive in too deeply here but would be my largest reason of concern in terms of this process replacing the existing film ratings (G-R18), with the potential for people to view higher scare ratings as a challenge rather than a warning.

Scare Factor uncovers the scariness of Horror films for users based on keywords in reviews without people having to watch the film to find out, or relying on purely anecdotal evidence. Whilst somewhat comprehensive it doesn't look for some key themes in horror, and could push users to look for more and more scary films untill they find their limit. Due to the large scale of reviews the website is taking from it does conceal the quality of the reviews it chooses, in it's weighting it does hold the Gaurdian, and Rodger Ebert to higher standards, but most films in the catalogue don't have reviews due to the low brow perception people have of horror films.